

Distinction–Persistence Theory (DPT)

Joshua D. Moats
Originator

Abstract

Distinction–Persistence Theory (DPT) is a constraint-based framework that studies what structures remain identifiable under sustained, legitimate pressure. Rather than treating matter, identity, or information as primitive, DPT treats persistence itself as the conserved quantity from which stable structure emerges.

1. Core Question

What keeps working after everything easy, rewarded, explained, or enforced is gone? If a structure disappears under legitimate pressure, it is not fundamental.

2. Axioms

Axiom I — Identity Existence Condition

An entity exists if and only if there exists a projection operator Π such that the persistence functional $P(\Pi) > 0$.

Axiom II — Overhead Optimization Principle

Systems spontaneously reconfigure when a configuration with lower canonical overhead exists.

Axiom III — Congestion–Innovation Limit

Scaling pressure forces either structural innovation or collapse.

3. Scope and Intent

DPT is not metaphysics and not a narrative philosophy. It is a constraint framework designed to be cheap to specify, expensive to deny, and hostile to post-hoc flexibility. This document establishes the foundational spine intended for formal extension.